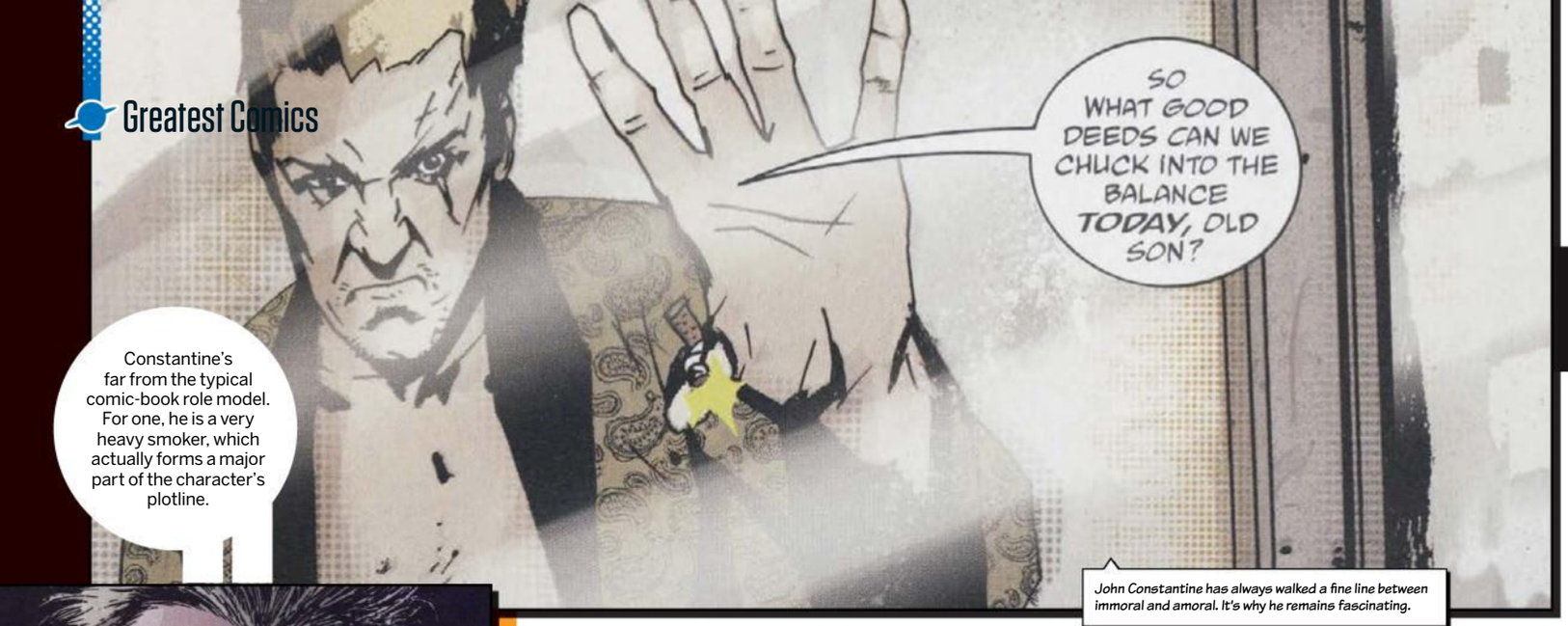


Constantine's far from the typical comic-book role model. For one, he is a very heavy smoker, which actually forms a major part of the character's plotline.

John Constantine has always walked a fine line between immoral and amoral. It's why he remains fascinating.



Constantine always exists on the fringe of the real world and mystical. He's the true outcast of comics.

Covering all of the bases

Hellblazer's best cover artists

Hellblazer is a title that has become known for its striking covers and it could be argued that it was the first regular comic book to use its covers to make a very specific point. The first cover artist, Dave McKean, even built some of the images for his work. The list of artists who have graced its covers is very impressive indeed: Dave McKean, Kent Williams, Tim Bradstreet, Simon Bisley, Sean Phillips, Glenn Fabry, Lee Bermejo and David Lloyd.

Dillon sees the appeal of the character as very simple: "Constantine is a different sort of character in a well-used genre. In a world of sorcery and demons he's no Merlin or Doctor Strange but a down-to-earth type who you wouldn't look twice at if you saw him in the pub. This has given his writers the flexibility to write more realistic stories with only a hint of fantasy if they chose to do so. Those stories always contrasted nicely with the more epic 'angel and demon' tales. Another difference is that, even though it was aimed at a mainly American audience, it is a very British book but Constantine was not the sort of Brit the Americans were used to seeing in their media. Rather than an upper class reserved type, he was a working-class chancer with a roguish charm and a liking for a pint and a smoke. Long may he continue," he revealed.

Ennis and Dillon cast a long shadow on the series with their run and whoever took over the title after them would have a hard act to follow. When the pair left to create *Preacher* for Vertigo, *Hellblazer*'s reins were briefly handed over to another British writer, Eddie Campbell, after a one-issue return from the man who started it all, Jamie Delano. Campbell's run only lasted for four issues but Paul Jenkins, an ex-pat Yorkshireman who had worked for *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* publisher Mirage, took over with artist Sean Phillips, who had come from Fleetway, where he'd drawn *New Statesmen* for *Crisis* and Devlin Waugh for the *Judge Dredd Megazine*. Jenkins increased Constantine's circle of friends and made it a less violent book than it was under Ennis and Dillon's tenure and he was on *Hellblazer* for 39 issues, longer than any of his predecessors. The title celebrated its 100th issue under Jenkins and Phillips, too, but its popularity wasn't what it was with Ennis and Dillon, despite the fact that visually it was some of Sean Phillips' best work to date.

Ennis came back for a four-issue story but Dillon wasn't with him: it was illustrated by John Higgins instead, so some of the spark that Ennis brought to the book on his original run was lacking.

The next writer who took on Constantine was Essex-based Warren Ellis. At the time, Ellis was a hot new writer, known for WildStorm's acclaimed *Planetary* series and critically lauded superhero book *Stormwatch*. He seemed eminently qualified to write the adventures of the sardonic mage, as he had displayed his credentials in *Transmetropolitan* for Vertigo, which admittedly was a science-fiction title, but there was plenty of urban horror there too. But his run was truncated over a controversy about a story he wrote about student-on-student shootings in American schools. In the wake of the real-life shooting at Columbine, there had been a change in editorial policy at DC and they chose not to publish the story. Ellis was off *Hellblazer*.

After a two-issue stint by Croatian creator Darko Macan, the next man to take over the title was a first for *Hellblazer*, as it was an American writer. Brian Azzarello had proven himself on award-winning book *100 Bullets*, also for Vertigo, so he seemed like a good fit. He wasn't

HELLBLAZER

On the shelf

Key Hellblazer storylines



Original Sins, issues 1-9 (1987-1988)
Writer: Jamie Delano
Artists: John Ridgway, Alfredo Alcala
This was the first run with Constantine as the main protagonist, with Delano relocating the action to a late-Eighties England, accompanied by suitably creepy art from John Ridgway and distinctive covers by Dave McKean.



Dangerous Habits, issues 41-46 (1991)
Writer: Garth Ennis
Artists: Will Simpson, Mark Pennington
Dangerous Habits is the story that the film was loosely based on, where Ennis made the title his own, giving Constantine a seemingly incurable disease and pitting him against the forces of Hell.



Fear And Loathing, issues 62-67, Special 1 (1993)
Writer: Garth Ennis
Artist: Steve Dillon
Ennis shifts the status quo here with Constantine homeless and at the mercy of the King of Vampires. Ennis's more personal tales are matched by Steve Dillon's simple but brilliant artwork.



Rake At The Gates Of Hell, issues 78-83, Heartland 1 (1994)
Writer: Garth Ennis
Artist: Steve Dillon
Constantine has made a deal with the Devil and here he comes to collect. Plus we see the fate of Kit. A true slice of urban horror that shows why Ennis and Dillon cast such a long shadow over the series.



Sins Of The Father, issue 100 (1996)
Writer: Paul Jenkins
Artist: Sean Phillips
As Constantine lies in a coma, he takes a tour of Hell and seemingly meets his damned father. Jenkins was adept at stories with emotional depth and, like Dillon, Phillips has an artistic simplicity that connects with the reader.